

Impact: High Difficulty: Medium Misuse risk: Low

WHY IT WORKS

Contempt — expressed through eye-rolls, dismissive tone, or sarcastic framing — activates the deepest threat response and permanently damages credibility. Separating your disagreement from any signal of disrespect keeps the conversation about ideas rather than status.

WHAT IT IS (AND ISN'T)

- Not agreeing to keep the peace — the disagreement itself stays fully intact.
- Not sandwiching criticism in compliments — people see through padding.
- It is removing the sneer: challenging the idea at full strength while signalling the person still has your respect.

THE PAYOFF

How it lands: I can bring them my half-formed ideas — they will challenge the thinking, not me.

Principle: People can absorb almost any disagreement about their ideas, and almost none about their worth.

What you gain

- Disagreements that make decisions better instead of relationships worse
- A reputation for being safe to think out loud with
- Influence that survives being on the losing side of an argument
- Earlier warnings — people bring you problems while they are still small
- Less defensiveness aimed back at you

Why most people fail at it

- Their words disagree with the idea while their face dismisses the person.
- They reach for sarcasm when they feel most certain.
- They treat being right as licence to be harsh.
- They save disagreement until it has fermented into resentment.

CORE FORMULA

Disagree with the idea -> Stay curious -> No dismissal signals

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Before disagreeing, check your face and tone. Remove any dismissal — eye-roll, sigh, 'obviously', sarcasm. Then disagree with the position, not the person.

BEST FOR

- High-stakes disagreements where the relationship must stay intact
- Peer-to-peer pushback in professional settings
- Disagreeing with someone more senior without damaging the relationship
- Debates where you are likely to be wrong about something

METHOD, STEP BY STEP

1. Strip — Strip the dismissal signals

Clear tone, face, and body language of contempt before you speak: no sighs, eye-rolls, sarcasm, or 'obviously'. The content of your disagreement never gets a hearing if the delivery sneers.

Leaks contempt: 'Obviously that would never work.'

Clean: 'I do not think that works, and I can say exactly why.'

2. Target — Disagree with the idea, not the person

Aim every sentence at the position, the plan, or the data — never at competence or character. The sharper your disagreement, the more precisely it should be targeted.

At the person: 'You clearly have not thought this through.'

At the idea: 'This plan assumes demand stays flat — I think that assumption fails.'

3. Stay — Stay genuinely curious

Hold the possibility that you are missing something, and ask like you mean it. Curiosity is not a softener — it is how you find out whether your disagreement survives contact with their reasoning.

Fake curiosity: 'Enlighten me. How could that possibly work?'

Real curiosity: 'What am I not seeing that makes you confident here?'

FIELD TIP

Contempt leaks through the channel you are not watching.

You can script perfect words and still lose the exchange through a sigh, a smirk, an eye-roll, or the word 'obviously'. Before disagreeing, check the non-verbal channel first — it is the one they believe.

Situation: A colleague proposes something you think is clearly wrong.

Don't: (Sigh) 'Right. Okay. Sure. Let's examine that.'

Do: 'I see it differently — walk me through your thinking and then I will give you mine.'

PHRASE BANK

Disagreement Openers · Stating the difference without contempt

- "I see this differently — my view is..."
- "I do not think that is quite right, and here is why."
- "I want to push back on one specific part of that."
- "I disagree, and I want to explain my reasoning."
- "That is not how I read the situation — here is my read."
- "I would reach a different conclusion from the same data."
- "I think there is a better option, and I want to explain why."
- "I have a different view on this, and I think it matters."

Curiosity Phrases · Staying open while disagreeing

- "Help me understand how you got there."
- "I want to make sure I am disagreeing with what you actually said."
- "Is there something I am missing that would change my view?"
- "Walk me through the part I am not seeing."
- "I might be wrong — what would change your position?"
- "I want to understand your reasoning before I push back harder."

Disagreeing Upward · Pushing back on someone senior

- "Can I offer a different read before we lock this in?"
- "I want to flag a risk in this plan while there is still time to adjust."
- "You may well see something I do not — from where I sit, X looks like a problem."
- "I would not be doing my job if I did not raise this."
- "If we go this route, I want my concern on the record — then I am fully behind the decision."
- "May I push back on one part of that?"

Meeting Disagreement · Dissent that keeps the room working

- "I want to offer a counter-view so we pressure-test this properly."
- "Before we converge — can I argue the other side for two minutes?"
- "I agree with the goal and disagree with the route."
- "There is a version of this I could support — it differs in one key way."
- "Let me steelman the proposal first, then say where I part ways."

Heat Reducers · When the disagreement got sharp

- "That came out harder than I intended. The disagreement stands; the edge does not."
- "We have drifted from the issue to each other. Can we come back to the issue?"
- "I am arguing to win instead of to understand. Let me reset."
- "We clearly both care about this. That is a good starting point."
- "Can we take five and come back to it? I want to disagree better than this."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Dismissive sigh, eye-roll, or 'obviously not'
Better: I do not think that is the right approach.
Best: I disagree — and I want to explain my reasoning.
2. Weak: Aggressive disagreement: 'That is completely wrong'
Better: I do not agree with that conclusion.
Best: I reach a different conclusion. Here is what I am seeing.
3. Weak: Disguised contempt: 'Well, I suppose if you want to look at it that way...'
Better: There are other ways to look at this.
Best: Direct disagreement with no passive-aggressive framing.

DECISION TREE

If You disagree strongly and feel contempt rising

Pause. Separate the idea from the person. Then respond.
"I want to be direct about this without being dismissive."

If The other person is using contempt on you

Name it calmly without matching it.
"I notice that landed with some edge. I would rather talk about the actual issue."

If You disagree but are not sure you are right

Disagree tentatively. Stay curious.
"I think this is wrong, but I want to understand your reasoning before I say that more firmly."

If The disagreement is personal as well as professional

Separate the professional point from the personal dimension explicitly.
"I want to keep this on the work question, not on the personal level."

If You have been right about this before and feel vindicated

Be careful. Contempt creeps in through 'told you so' energy.
"I think this confirms the concern I raised. I am not saying I was right — I am saying the data suggests..."

SCENARIOS

Colleague proposes an approach you think is flawed

Name the disagreement specifically. Stay on the idea. — "I think there is a problem with the approach, and I want to name it clearly."

Senior person makes a claim you believe is incorrect

Disagree respectfully on the substance, not the status. — "I want to respectfully push back on that — the data I have seen suggests otherwise."

Debate where emotions are running high

Slow down. Remove contempt signals. State disagreement plainly. — "I disagree with that and I want to explain why — without this getting heated."

You realise mid-disagreement you might be wrong

Say so. It builds more credibility than pressing on. — "Actually — hold on. I want to reconsider that."

WORKED EXAMPLE

Without the technique

You: (sighing) That would never work — I can't believe we're still discussing this.

Colleague: (shuts down, stops contributing to the meeting)

With the technique

You: I see it differently — I think there's a real risk this approach misses. Can I show you what the data suggests?

Colleague: Sure — show me.

COMMON MISTAKES

Contempt through the back channel

Sounds like: Polite words, rolled eyes

Better: Match your non-verbals to your words — or say nothing yet.

Sarcasm as disagreement

Sounds like: 'Oh brilliant, another reorg. That always goes well.'

Better: 'I am sceptical — the last two reorgs cost more than they returned.'

Character verdicts

Sounds like: 'That is naive.'

Better: 'I think that underestimates the supplier risk.'

The fake question

Sounds like: 'Do you really think that is a good idea?'

Better: 'I do not think it is the right call — here is my reasoning.'

Winning the exchange, losing the person

Sounds like: Pressing every advantage until they go quiet

Better: 'We disagree on the route and agree on the destination. Let us work from there.'

Told-you-so energy when proven right

Sounds like: 'As I said at the time...'

Better: 'The data backs the earlier concern. How do we adjust?'

READING THE ROOM

Signs it is working

- The other person hears your disagreement without getting defensive.
- Disagreements stay on the substance rather than turning personal.
- You feel firm and clear without feeling aggressive.
- The relationship stays intact after the disagreement.

Signs to adjust

- Your tone sounds like contempt even when your words do not.
- You are staying so careful that you are not actually disagreeing.
- The other person reads your neutrality as agreement.
- You are suppressing contempt rather than genuinely releasing it.

WHEN NOT TO USE

- When the other person's position is genuinely harmful and requires sharp, unambiguous challenge — softness can imply tacit endorsement.
- In high-stakes negotiations where tactical firmness is operationally necessary.
- When you have already tried respectful disagreement repeatedly and the priority is clarity over tone.

RECOVERY LINES

Best line: 'I disagree with the idea, and I realise it just sounded like I disagreed with you.'

- "That came out with more edge than the point needed."
- "I dismissed that too fast. Say it again — I will actually listen."
- "I was scoring points instead of making one. Let me restate it properly."
- "My tone just undercut my own argument. The argument is still worth hearing."

- "I disagree with the idea, and I realise it just sounded like I disagreed with you."
- "Let me take the sarcasm out and say it straight."

TECHNIQUE CHAINS

Pushback chain

Acknowledge the goal -> state the disagreement -> give the reason -> invite the counter

We both want this shipped by March.

I disagree that cutting testing gets us there.

The last release we rushed cost us three weeks in fixes.

What am I missing that makes the risk acceptable this time?

De-escalation chain

Name the heat -> separate issue from person -> restate both positions -> resume

This has got sharper than it needs to be.

The question is the budget, not either of us.

You think we underspend on brand; I think the funnel leaks first.

Can we test which assumption is right?

RELATED TECHNIQUES

TC017 — Agreement Before Disagreement

Agreement Before Disagreement finds the shared ground first, so the pushback lands on a foundation.

TC016 — Validation Without Agreement

Validation Without Agreement lets you honour their reasoning fully before dismantling the conclusion.

TC004 — Repair Opening

Repair Opening is the recovery move when a disagreement has already turned into a rupture.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Contempt audit

Notice every time you feel contempt in a conversation today — even mild contempt. Do not act — just notice.

Day 2 — Separate idea from person

In one disagreement, consciously target the idea not the person. Notice the difference.

Day 3 — Remove dismissal signals

Eliminate sighs, eye-rolls, 'obviously', and sarcasm from one disagreement today.

Day 4 — Stay curious

After disagreeing, ask one genuine question about their reasoning.

Day 5 — Direct disagreement practice

State one disagreement plainly using 'I disagree because...' with no softening or hedging.

Day 6 — High-stakes practice

Use this in one real disagreement that matters — with a colleague, manager, or partner.

Day 7 — Calibration

Did your disagreements stay productive? Did the relationships hold? Was anything lost by being more direct?

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I disagree with the idea, not the person?
- Did I remove contempt signals — tone, face, word choice?
- Did I state the disagreement plainly rather than hiding it?
- Did I stay curious about their reasoning?
- Did I avoid sarcasm, eye-rolls, and dismissive language?
- Did I stay on the substance of the disagreement?
- Did the relationship remain intact after the disagreement?
- Did I consider that I might be wrong?